1.1 The Age of Exploration

Imagine setting sail in a direction no one you know has ever gone. Would you be excited or scared? European explorers probably felt both as they set out without smartphones, GPS, or even accurate maps. Now, that's an adventure!

MAIN IDEA The search for a western route to Asia during the late 15th and early 16th centuries opened the Americas to European settlement.



The exact location where Christopher Columbus and his crew landed in October 1492 remains a mystery, but this sandy beach on the island of Samana Cay in the Bahamas might be one possibility. Scientists used Columbus's navigation log with computer modeling to determine his journey.

COLUMBUS SETS SAIL

In the 1440s, Portugal established trade on the West African coast. Seeing the success of the Portuguese, merchants from other countries also tried to participate. However, Pope Nicholas V gave Portugal sole possession of the African and Indian coasts in 1455.

King Ferdinand and **Queen Isabella** of Spain were determined to continue trading despite the pope's decree. They found a strong willed and obsessed navigator to search for a western route to Asia. **Christopher Columbus** gladly accepted the challenge for the Spanish monarchs. In October 1492, Columbus and his fleet of ships arrived in the Bahamas. As he traveled from island to island, he believed—incorrectly, of course—that he was exploring islands south of China. He encountered people called the **Taino** (TIE-noh) and received gold in return for his goods. Leaving a few men behind, Columbus set out for home in January 1493. When he returned a year later, he discovered that the Taino had killed all his crew after his men had abused and badly harmed them. The men's actions were the start of the mistreatment of Native Americans that would last for centuries.

Ferdinand and Isabella petitioned Pope Alexander VI to allow them to colonize the lands Columbus claimed for Spain. Spain's economy was based on **mercantilism**, a system in which countries kept

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the sole right to trade with their colonies. Under this system, more colonies equaled more wealth—and power.

In 1494, the **Treaty of Tordesillas** established a boundary—called the **Line of Demarcation**—that passed vertically through the Atlantic and present-day Brazil. The boundary gave Portugal a portion of South America to colonize, control of the sea routes around Africa, and control of the Atlantic slave trade. Spain received permission to colonize all of the land west of the line.

Both Portugal and Spain also sent **missionaries**, or people who travel to other places to spread their own religion, to these new lands. The two countries wanted to convert the people who lived there to Christianity.

EXPLORING NEW LANDS

As Europeans continued exploring lands in the Western Hemisphere, they realized that Columbus had not reached Asia. In 1499 and 1501, the Italian captain **Amerigo Vespucci** (uh-MEHR-ih-goh veh-SPOO-chee) made two voyages—one for Spain and one for Portugal. His explorations revealed that South America was a huge landmass, which he later named **Mundus Novus**, meaning "New World" in Latin. Of course, the land was only new to the Europeans; Native Americans had already been living there for centuries. Vespucci's explorations inspired a German cartographer to name the continents *America*, after Vespucci's given name, *Amerigo.*

In 1513, Vasco Núñez Balboa led explorers across the Isthmus of Panama, and they became the first Europeans to see the eastern rim of the Pacific Ocean. Balboa claimed everything he saw for Spain.

Six years later, Ferdinand Magellan departed Spain with five ships to sail around South America and on to Asia. But the Pacific Ocean was much wider than the navigator expected. By the time the ships reached the island of Guam, the sailors were near starvation. After inhabitants killed Magellan, another sailor, Sebastian del Cano, took command of the one remaining ship. He returned to Spain after a three-year voyage, completing the first navigation around the world.



The Controversy Over Columbus Day

Was Christopher Columbus a great explorer or a ruthless invader? The question is at the heart of the controversy over Columbus Day, an annual mid-October holiday that celebrates the explorer's "achievements."

Supporters of the holiday argue that Columbus opened two continents to trade and further settlement, forever changing the world. Opponents say the holiday glorifies a man who nearly destroyed the livelihood of the native peoples of the Americas. They argue instead for celebrating Indigenous Peoples Day to remember the native peoples lost through European colonization. Various city councils have replaced Columbus Day observances with celebrations of Indigenous Peoples Day. The state of South Dakota renamed the holiday Native Americans' Day.

HISTORICAL THINKING

1. **READING CHECK** Why did the Spanish want to find a western route to Asia?
2. **DRAW CONCLUSIONS** In what ways did the Treaty of Tordesillas support Spain's mercantilist economy?
3. **IDENTIFY MAIN IDEAS AND DETAILS** How did further exploration prove that Christopher Columbus had not landed in Asia?

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